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WPP Key Metric Slides as Main Segments Decline

Like-for-like revenue less pass-through costs was down 6.7% in the first quarter

By Adrià Calatayud Follow and Najat Kantouar Follow

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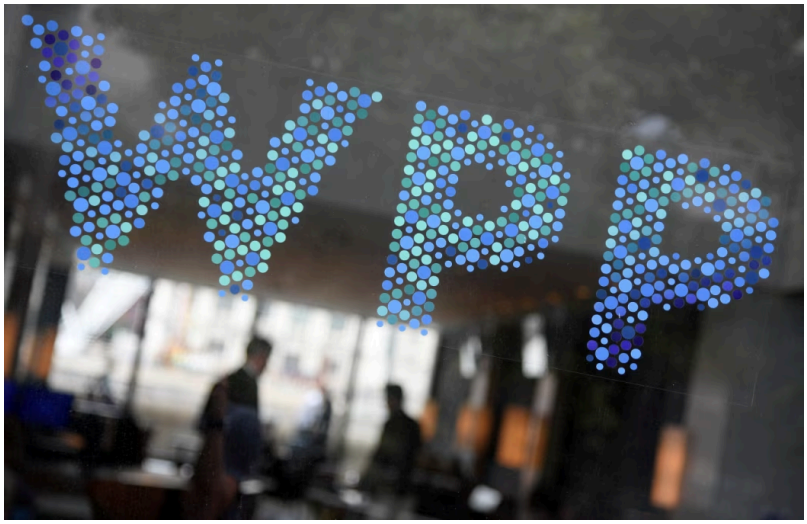

WPP maintained its full-year guidance, despite continued near-term uncertainty due to the Middle East conflict. TOBY MELVILLE/REUTERS

WPP said its key top-line metric fell in the first quarter due to a decline across all its main units, as the company seeks to turn around its fortunes after a series of account losses and a leadership change.

The U.K. advertising group said Tuesday that like-for-like revenue less pass-through costs was down 6.7% in the first quarter compared with the year-earlier period.

Analysts polled by Vuma had forecast a 8% decline for the metric, which is a closely watched measure of the company's top-line performance that

excludes fees and other expenses passed on to clients as well as the effects of currency movements, acquisitions and asset sales.

"While it will take time to outpace historical losses, our first quarter results are in line with expectations and ahead of the fourth quarter 2025," Chief Executive Cindy Rose said.

On a like-for-like basis, revenue less pass-through costs declined 7.4% in its global integrated agencies unit, reflecting prior-year client losses. Meanwhile, revenue less pass-through costs in its public relations and specialist agencies divisions fell 2.6% and 2.3%, respectively.

Despite continued near-term uncertainty due to the Middle East conflict, WPP maintained its full-year guidance, it said. The group previously flagged that recent account losses would result in a like-for-like revenue less pass-through costs declining by a figure in the mid to high-single percentage digits for the first half, with an improvement expected in the second.

The company still anticipates full-year headline operating profit margin to be 12% to 13% and adjusted operating cash flow before working capital between 800 million and 900 million pounds ($1.08 billion to $1.22 billion).

The owner of agencies such as Ogilvy and VML is grappling with the consequences of a string of client defections in recent years that hurt its results and share price, and paved the way for a change at the helm. The challenges come at a time the ad industry as a whole is confronting investor fears about the long-term impact of artificial intelligence on their business and short-term uncertainty due to the conflict in the Middle East.

In February, WPP Chief Executive Cindy Rose set out a three-year plan to revive the company, overhauling its structuring and leaving the door open to shedding noncore units, with the aim of returning to organic growth over the course of 2027.

The company has flagged it is starting to see some green shoots, signaling it expected its performance to recover throughout the year.

With wins from big clients like Estee Lauder, WPP was the No. 1 among the world's biggest ad agency holding companies by net new business intake in the first quarter, according to J.P. Morgan.

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